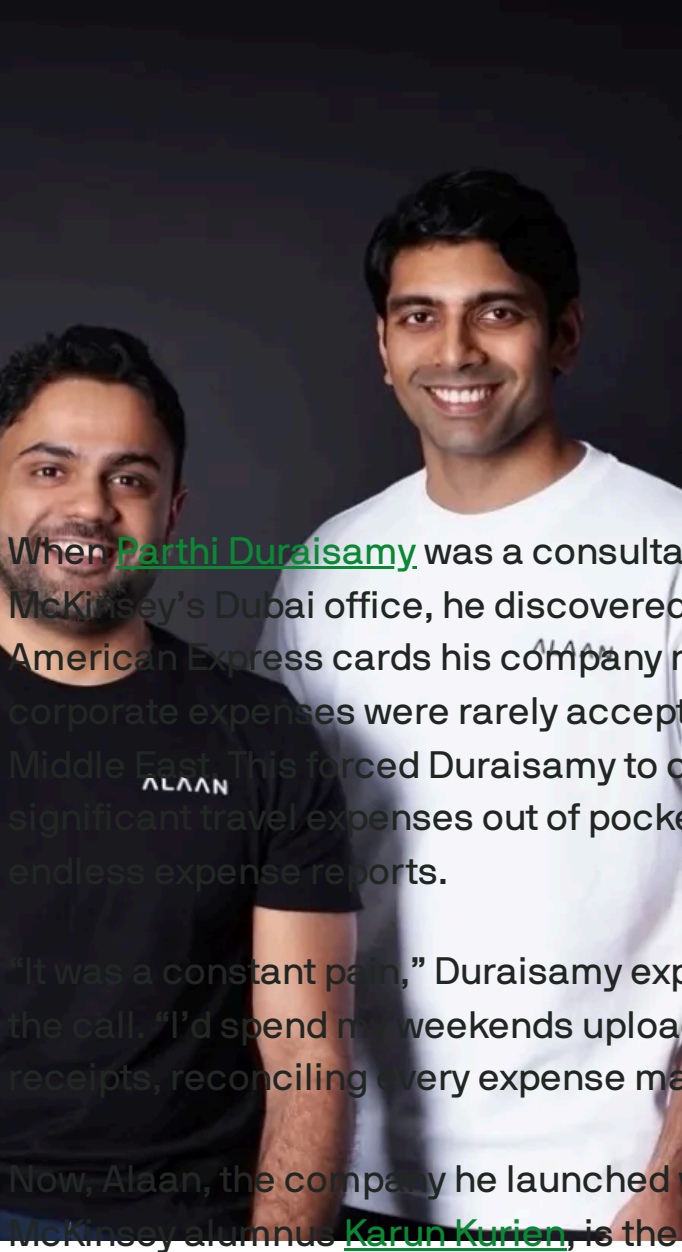


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AI



**AI-powered fintech Alaan
raises \$48M, one of the
largest Series A rounds in
MENA**



When [Parthi Duraisamy](#) was a consultant at McKinsey's Dubai office, he discovered that the American Express cards his company relied on for corporate expenses were rarely accepted in the Middle East. This forced Duraisamy to cover significant travel expenses out of pocket and file endless expense reports.

"It was a constant pain," Duraisamy explained on the call. "I'd spend my weekends uploading receipts, reconciling every expense manually."

Now, Alaan, the company he launched with fellow McKinsey alumnus [Karun Kurien](#), is the Middle East's leading spend management platform. It just announced that it raised \$48 million in Series A funding led by Peak XV Partners (formerly Sequoia Capital India & SEA) with participation from others like founders of 885 Capital, Y Combinator, 468 Capital, and Pioneer Fund.

Founders of some of Alaan's unicorn customers, like Hosam Arab (Tabby), Mudassir Sheikha (Careem), and Khalid Al Ameri, a well-known YouTuber in the region, also invested.

This is one of the largest Series A rounds for a fintech in the region, compared to Saudi Arabia's buy now, pay later platform Tamara, [which raised \\$110 million](#) a couple of years ago.

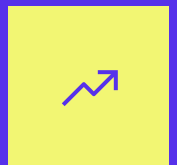
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“The category has demonstrated strong product-market fit in the MENA region, and Alaan stands out as the category leader,” said GV Ravishankar, managing director at Peak XV. “Their customer-centric and product-led mindset has enabled them to build solutions tailored to modern finance teams.” (Peak XV also participated in a large Series B round last month, backing [UAE’s proptech Huspy](#).)

Alaan’s path to category leadership wasn’t without challenges, however.

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TC

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While the fintech raised a \$2.5 million seed round in mid-2021, it couldn’t launch for nearly a year, largely due to regulatory complexities and the need for banking partnerships in the UAE. Its recent expansion into Saudi Arabia posed similar hurdles, taking years to secure approvals from the country’s apex bank before finally launching this January.

“The biggest challenge we faced, both in the UAE and Saudi Arabia, was simply going live,” the CEO shared.

Yet, Duraisamy said the fintech was able to move fast in other ways such as in Alaan's pioneering move to integrate Apple Pay into its B2B offerings, something previously unavailable to finance teams in the region.

In early 2023, the company also claimed to be the first in the Middle East to integrate OpenAI into its services, a move Duraisamy says shaped the company's current product strategy. Initially, Alaan rolled out a chatbot, anticipating that users would enjoy conversational interactions around their spending. But the feature failed to gain traction.

Lesson learned, the fintech shifted focus, realizing customers got more value when AI worked in the background. Alaan began using AI to help streamline processes like receipt matching, reconciliation, and VAT extraction — a particularly valuable use case in the region, where the platform helps businesses navigate complex VAT regulations and reclaimable tax.

The company claims its spend management platform has already saved finance teams more than 1.5 million hours of manual work. It's a number Alaan expects to grow as it continues to invest in automation.

Since launching in 2022, Alaan has processed over 2.5 million transactions for more than 1,500 finance teams across major regional enterprises, including G42, Careem, Tabby, and Lulu Group.

What's more, the company is profitable, Duraisamy says, noting that it spent \$5 million to generate \$10 million in revenue. Duraisamy credits YC and his mentors for instilling a disciplined approach in a market where many fintechs are focused on payment volumes.

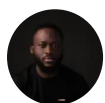
Now Alaan is looking to replicate its growth in Saudi Arabia, where it launched earlier this year and has been doubling transaction volumes month over month for the past six months, according to the startup.

The Series A will accelerate this expansion, allowing the company to scale hiring across sales, customer success, and compliance, while also doubling down on AI-driven finance automation.

While the 4-year-old fintech, which is equipping MENA finance teams with AI agents, has now raised one of the largest Series A rounds in MENA, I asked Duraisamy if Ramp’s explosive growth — its [valuation has doubled this year after raising three rounds](#) — played a role in investors betting big on Alaan.

“When you talk to investors, what really matters for a company at our stage is the fundamentals: how capital-efficient we are, how much revenue we generate, how strong our go-to-market motion is,” he said. “We are not in a market where you know size is an advantage, like the U.S. or Europe. So, regardless of whether Ramp was able to raise or not, I think we would have raised this much because our fundamentals were very strong.”

Topics: [AI](#) [Fintech](#) [MENA](#)



Tage Kene-Okafor

Reporter, Africa |

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IMAGE CREDITS: COTU VENTURES

VENTURE



COTU Ventures launches \$54M fund for pre-seed and seed startups in MENA

Tage Kene-Okafor — 9:10 PM PST · February 26, 2024

Dubai-based early-stage venture capital firm [COTU Ventures](#) is announcing that it has raised \$54 million for its inaugural fund to support startups in the Middle East from pre-seed to seed stages.

With a final close achieved last year, COTU Ventures, which identifies and backs founders from the inception to post-product launch, invests between \$500,000 and \$2 million while reserving capital for follow-on investments.

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Over the past two and a half years, COTU Ventures has actively deployed capital into startups across the GCC (Gulf Cooperation Council), focusing primarily on the UAE and Saudi Arabia, Egypt and Pakistan. The firm has already backed over 20 early-stage startups across various sectors, as outlined in its statement.

Founder and general partner [Amir Farha](#) revealed in an interview with TechCrunch that COTU Ventures is inclined slightly toward fintech and B2B software. However, the firm is open to opportunities across other sectors. Noteworthy investments by COTU Ventures include [Huspy](#), a UAE mortgage platform backed by Peak XV and Founders Fund, and Egyptian fintech startup [MoneyHash](#).

“The consumer wave happened with Careem and some other applications. Today, businesses are lagging a bit behind, so there’s a huge opportunity to build software to help solve many of their problems. We are also interested in high-margin industries where technology can play a massive role and capitalize on margin efficiencies,” said Farha on the opportunities COTU is keen on.

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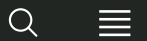
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MENA and GCC region, was one of the earliest investments Farha made as a VC at his previous firm, BECO Capital.

Several years after working at a corporate VC investing across the U.K. and Sweden and later running the first seed fund and angel network in the region backed by the Dubai government, Farha launched BECO Capital in 2012, where he took part in running the firm's investments, strategy and firm building efforts for its first fund (\$50 million) and second fund (\$100 million) before departing to launch COTU Ventures.

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While at BECO Capital, Farha and his partner returned the first fund, whose portfolio includes General Atlantic-backed PropertyFinder and Fresha, following [Uber's acquisition of Careem](#). He also noted that BECO Capital's second fund, which includes well-capitalized startups such as Kitopi and [MaxAB](#), "is doing really well."

Reflecting on the evolving investment landscape, Farha explained how BECO Capital was actively involved in seed rounds ranging from a few hundred thousand dollars to Series B rounds of around \$5 million before the ecosystem evolved to accommodate more sizable funds and bigger later-stage investments. In this time, venture capital investments in the GCC region experienced significant growth, soaring from \$20 million in 2012 to over \$2 billion by 2020.

Sequoia Capital India and Founders Fund back UAE-based proptech startup Huspy in its \$37M round



Founders Fund has made its first investment in the Middle East by backing UAE-based proptech startup Huspy. The \$37 million Series A round, one of the largest at this stage in MENA, was led by

Sequoia Capital India. The round also welcomed participation from Fifth Wall, the largest VC firm backing real estate and proptech. [Continue reading](#)

As BECO Capital shifted its focus toward later-stage investments with larger funds, Farha decided to depart in 2020 and launch COTU Ventures, doubling down on early-stage investments. This decision, he explained, was driven by the recognition of a market gap. Despite the significant maturation of the GCC tech ecosystem in terms of capital and talent, there remained a crucial need for support beyond just funding at the earliest stages of startup development.

Farha asserts that a founder's upbringing and early life experiences can offer valuable insights into their potential for success. At COTU Ventures, he emphasizes the importance of candid conversations that delve deep into a founder's personal and professional journey, exploring significant life events and decisions. By fostering such open dialogue, COTU Ventures aims to establish trust and strong connections with founders, enabling the firm to make more informed investment decisions.

Moreover, Farha highlights that this strategy allows the firm to provide strategic guidance on fundraising, organizational development, and go-to-market strategy. He added that the venture capital firm also facilitates introductions to key stakeholders such as customers, hires, and

potential follow-on investors, offering comprehensive support to its portfolio companies as they navigate Series A rounds and beyond.

“I love the chaos of the earlier stages where you’re discovering, experimenting and testing. Things look great, but one day, things look difficult, and then you are trying to help solve problems along the way. So that environment suits me as an investor well,” remarked Farha. “Also, there’s a gap. The region is still early and nobody’s owning early-stage with conviction. You have the bigger firms investing smaller checks in the pre-seed stages but don’t spend enough time helping them until they reach product market fit. So, I think there’s that space to be the go-to company that founders want to have on their cap table.”

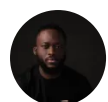
COTU Ventures’ limited partners include Lunate, Mubadala, Dubai Future District Fund, Arab Bank, Bupa KSA, and GPs from VCs, including Foundry Group, Tribe Capital, Stride, and several family offices.

“We’re proud to have backed a fund that’s distinguished not only by its impressive portfolio but by the exceptional leadership and track record of its founding partner, Amir,” said Sharif El-Badawi, CEO of Dubai Future District Fund, in a statement. “Our confidence in Amir stems from his deep passion for supporting founders and his proven ability to find remarkable investment opportunities before anyone else.”

Topics: [Africa](#) [COTU Ventures](#)

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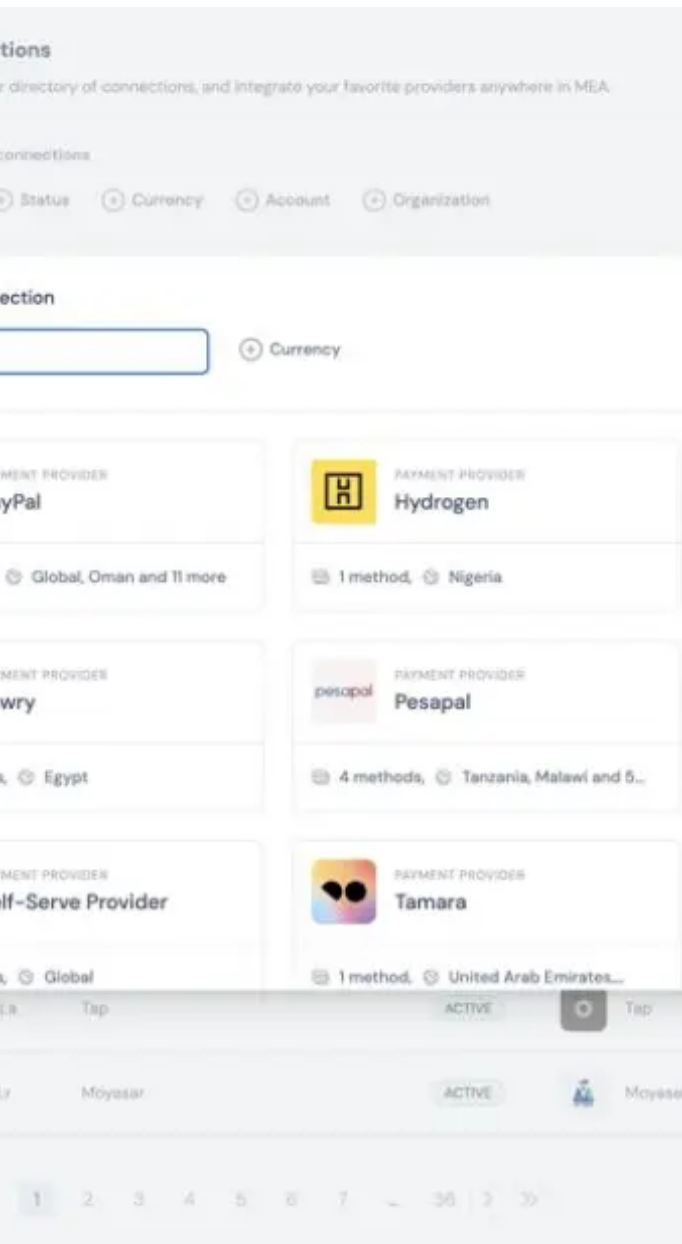


IMAGE CREDITS: MONEYHASH

FINTECH

MoneyHash, which provides single access to payment services in MENA, banks \$5.2M

Tage Kene-Okafor — 3:00 AM PST · January 21, 2025

When merchants or companies launch online, they typically start by partnering with one or two

payment processors. But as they grow and expand into new regions, they often need to onboard additional payment partners to meet different customer (and sometimes regulatory) needs, a process that comes with some hurdles.

That's given rise to companies to help manage the process. Egypt's [MoneyHash](#) — which helps merchants across the Middle East and Africa manage complex payment stacks more easily — has raised \$5.2 million as it scales to target larger enterprises. The pre-Series A comes around a year after its last funding, when it [announced a \\$4.5 million seed round](#) in February 2024. In total, MoneyHash has raised over \$12 million since [Nader Abdelrazik](#) and [Mustafa Eid](#) launched the Egyptian fintech in early 2021.

The area that MoneyHash works in is classically described as “payment orchestration,” and in the fragmented world of payments — where a business might work with dozens of different providers to take, make, and bank payments — its star has risen with the growth of online transactions. Integrating multiple payment stacks can be operationally inefficient and technically complex, often taking in-house tech teams weeks to complete. These challenges are even more apparent across Africa and the Middle East due to the various payment methods and currencies. This is where payment orchestration platforms come in by aggregating and simplifying these payment processes across regions via APIs.

Abdelrazik and Eid founded MoneyHash after years of working in fintech and enterprise software and witnessing firsthand some of the problems. Put simply, payments are (perhaps obviously) the crux of how a business operates, grows, and makes a profit. But too often there were instead costly and risky bottlenecks, especially for smaller merchants: Payment failure rates in the region are

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three times the global average and cart abandonment is more than 20% higher than in developed markets. They saw orchestration as the solution: By their thinking, merchants without payment orchestration platforms are at the mercy of high operational costs and revenue leakage, and will find it hard to scale across regions.

“The opportunity to solve this is immense,” said CEO Abdelrazik. “In emerging markets, digital payments represent only a fraction of total transaction volume, suggesting massive growth potential in the coming decade. We’ve built MoneyHash specifically to help merchants overcome these complex challenges and turn payments from a liability into a strategic advantage.”

MoneyHash integrates with a merchant’s payment providers to give its customers a simplified way of working across that stack. It offers features like a unified API for pay-in and pay-out operations, customizable checkout, advanced transaction routing with fraud prevention, failure rate optimization, and detailed reporting tools. The company also supports recurring payments, virtual wallets, subscription management, and payment links, delivering an “all-in-one solution” for merchants, it said.

Just as you have a16z-backed [Payrails](#), Spreedly, Zooz, and Primer in the U.S., U.K., and Europe, MoneyHash serves customers across the Middle East and Africa. Abdelrazik said that’s what sets MoneyHash apart: its focus on emerging markets and its vast integration network, which includes over 300 pre-integrated APIs (with local and international processors and gateways like Adyen, Amazon Pay, Checkout, Fawry, Mono, Stripe, Tabby, and ValU) covering 100+ markets. QED-backed [Precium](#) (formerly Revio), a South African upstart, provides similar services in the region.



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MONEYHASH EXECUTIVE TEAM.

IMAGE CREDITS: MONEYHASH

MoneyHash initially focused on small merchants but began targeting larger enterprises in early 2024 with the launch of its enterprise suite, a move that has allowed the company to achieve notable scale.

“Without us, you can still do a lot of performance enhancements that will take years of work and studying. But when you add our software, all

performance metrics across the payment get to the highest level possible. We're talking about the authorization, conversion, and fraud rates. And we're pretty comprehensive," remarked CEO Abdelrazik.

"We're not focusing on only one performance metric to try to fix all the problems across the entire payment chain life cycle, which is what enterprises need. Enterprise doesn't want to solve one problem. They'll search for other problems. They want a comprehensive solution across the payment cycle, and that's what we do."

Enterprises across industries like consumer fintech, hospitality, e-commerce, and gaming now make up 35% of MoneyHash's clientele, a threefold increase in 2024. Key customers include BNPL unicorn Tamara, cloud kitchen leader Kitopi, and e-commerce platform Brands For Less.

According to the head of payments at Tamara, MoneyHash stands out in the region by "building an important point of difference," likely referring to its claims to help clients achieve a 10-20% increase in revenue generation while cutting go-to-market and development costs by 90%.

Meanwhile, Abdelrazik credits his startup's enterprise pipeline and long-term contracts helped in raising the pre-Series A funding. He said these customers fueled a 4x increase in processing volume and a 3x revenue increase over the past year, though specific figures remain undisclosed.

Global fintech investor Flourish Ventures led the round. Other investors include Saudi's Vision Ventures, Arab Bank's Xelerate, and Emurgo Kepple Ventures. The round also welcomed participation from Jason Gardner, founder and former CEO of Marqeta (his first check in the region), and existing

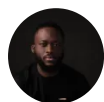
investors GitHub founder Tom Preston-Werner and COTU Ventures.

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